

How to Apply for Canadian Citizenship by Descent

Learn how to claim Canadian citizenship based on your ancestry under the new Bill C-3.

Author Bio

Hello there! I'm Bread and Roses (she/her). I'm a queer woman currently living in the United States, but planning to move to Canada. To make that happen, I applied for Canadian citizenship by descent under the amended C-3 citizenship bill. You can find my full story, along with templates and other free resources [on my website](#).

In 2025, I came to the sad realization that I couldn't safely stay in the United States much longer. I started researching countries, but was really struggling to find a good option.

Then, I saw that Canada was removing their first-generation descent limit for citizenship. The next day, I signed up for [Ancestry.com](#) and found enough information to figure out — MY GREAT-GRANDFATHER WAS CANADIAN! With that, the adventure began.

In this guide, in collaboration with other researchers and C-3 applicants at Help Me Leave, I'll share the process of applying for Canadian citizenship by descent. Keep reading to learn:

- **How the new law works**
- **What documents are needed to prove ancestry**
- **Sources to find your genealogy and family documents**
- **How to submit an application for citizenship**
- **Answers to frequently asked questions**

This guide is not legal advice. We are not immigration attorneys or a travel agency. Please consult the official IRCC sources linked throughout the guide.

What's the Law?

Canadian Citizenship as a legal status didn't exist until the [Canadian Citizenship Act of 1946](#). But it had some troubling (to say the least) sexist and racist components, not dissimilar to those in the United States. The [1977 Citizenship Act](#) reformed some of this. For example, it allowed people to derive nationality from their mother as well as their father. But it was far from inclusive.



“Lost Canadians”

A new requirement was established for Canadians to be registered with the government by a certain age, or they would lose their citizenship. This resulted in many Canadians accidentally losing their citizenship. After 9/11, the U.S. began to require passports for border crossings with Canada. When more Canadians began applying for passports, many learned they were no longer considered citizens. These people became known as "[lost Canadians](#)."

Activists and organizers fought for decades to create more equitable recognition for women, BIPOC, foreign-born, and Indigenous peoples. Finally, the Canadian legislature amended the 1976 Citizenship Act in 2009, 2015, and 2017.

Then, in 2023, the Ontario Superior Court of Justice ruled that the first-generation limit for citizenship by descent was unconstitutional because citizen rights depended on birth location. The court required [new legislation to repair the impacts on those affected](#). That brings us to [Bill C-3, "An Act to amend the Citizenship Act \(2025\)"](#), which came into effect on 15 December 2025.

What's the Generational Limit to Claim Canadian Citizenship by Descent?

If you were born before 15 December 2025, there is no generational limit.

The only limit is your ability to prove that you descended directly from a Canadian citizen. That descendant is your “generation zero (G0)” — your root to Canada, who was born in or naturalized in Canada. Generations following your G0 are retroactively considered citizens because they were born to a Canadian citizen.

Anecdotally, I've heard of approvals for up to nine generations back! However, those people likely have very strong family ancestry documentation. Typically, it gets very difficult (but not impossible) to find document proof after three generations.

Looking Forward

For future generations, people born after 15 December 2025 to a Canadian parent who was also born or adopted abroad **must prove that their parent spent three full years in Canada before their birth or adoption.**

How Can I Apply for Proof of Citizenship Under Bill C-3?

To reclaim lost citizenship, you need material proof that you are the direct descendant of a Canadian citizen. Per the [official Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada \(IRCC\) Checklist](#), you'll need the following documents to apply for proof of citizenship:

- Application for a Citizenship Certificate ([Form CIT0001](#))
- Document Checklist: Application for a Citizenship Certificate ([Form CIT0014](#))
- Two (2) identical [citizenship photos](#) (similar to passport photos) with your name and the date, name and address of the photographer on the back
- Two (2) [approved identity documents](#) (e.g., passport, driver's license, health insurance ID card)
- Payment receipt for \$75
- Your country-specific birth certificate displaying the name of your Canadian parent(s), issued by the appropriate government authority in the country where you were born
- Proof of any other nationalities acquired by you and your Canadian parent before February 15, 1977, if applicable to you
- Proof of lineage documentation: Color copies of the records establishing your descent from a Canadian citizen (birth certificates, marriage certificates, etc.)
- Explanation letter and supporting documents if [requesting urgent processing](#)
- Change of Sex or Gender Identifier ([Form IRM 0002](#)) (if applying for a gender marker different from what is listed on your birth certificate)

If you're submitting documents that aren't in English or French, provide color copies of translated documents. You'll also need a notarized sworn statement from the translator.

Note: If you're applying with other people, you also need to complete an [IMM 5476 Form](#) to act on their behalf. This isn't required for minor children, but it doesn't hurt to avoid confusion.

How Do I Prove My Canadian Ancestry?

The IRCC does not have exact guidelines on which records are sufficient proof of citizenship. Consular officials seem to be struggling to clarify new procedures. Plus, since this bill is so new, there's no prior evidence to fall back on.



However, thousands of people have applied and been approved. Based on that evidence, we have some ideas about their order of preference (from strongest to weakest):

- Birth certificate
- Birth record (like a town register for births)
- Baptism record

And then, if it lists the place of birth or parents, depending on what you're trying to prove:

- Marriage record and/or name change records
- Death record
- Other official records, such as military records, census records, court documents, and more
- Supporting materials such as photographs, newspaper articles, or a family tree

If you have a birth record, great! If you don't, move to the next item in the list. In general, the further down the list you need to go, the more records you should include. You can also write a cover letter to help the reviewing officer know what to look for.

Note: *The IRCC will not accept birth or marriage certificates issued in Quebec before January 1, 1994. If a birth or marriage occurred before 1994, make sure that the record was issued (i.e., printed) in 1994 or later.*

How to Gather Your Canadian Citizenship Records

The further back in time you need to go, the more challenging it can be to find records. Canada didn't have a standardized vital records system until the 1970s. That means you may need to rely on other records — often maintained by churches.

It's really a matter of luck whether or not official records exist for your family. But if they do, there are many resources to help prove your Canadian lineage. Here are several options to get records (or prove you tried to get them),

1. Library and Archives Canada (LAC) index

The [LAC index](#) contains a small collection of historic birth, marriage, death, divorce and estate records. You can also explore [Canadiana Heritage](#), a website of digitized LAC records on microfilm.

2. Ancestry.com

This is an [easy-to-use website](#) with a paid subscription that has tons of user-generated information. Make sure to carefully review any “hints” because sometimes the information is mislabeled, or it is for someone who has the same name but is not your relative.

3. FamilySearch.org

This is a [free website](#) run by the Church of Latter-Day Saints with a huge number of digital records.

4. Official Canadian census records

These [free records](#) are provided by the Canadian government for census information, with select records available back to 1926. **Note:** The transcriptions are often inaccurate or grainy. Search for other members of their family to find the right page and [use wildcards](#) to broaden the results.

5. Provincial archives

Provincial archives, such as the [Archives of Ontario](#) or Bibliothèque et Archives nationales du Québec, may have local records. Ontario has digitized most records, but you can also purchase copies of records or get help from an archivist. **Note:** Understandably, there’s been a massive increase in demand for these services, so these requests can take months to fulfill.

6. Private researchers

The Ontario Archives provides a list of [private researchers for hire](#). These people are professionals with varying prices. You will have to pay them for their time even if they don’t find the records that you’re looking for.

7. Volunteer researchers

For a free option, some volunteer researchers can help find documents. They are currently in high demand, so be patient with them and their time. There is a [list of document search volunteers on Reddit](#). If you have a [FamilySearch center nearby](#), they also have volunteers to help you search their records. **Note:** While Family Search is run by the Church of Latter-Day Saints, the volunteers do not proselytize people using their services.

8. Church archives

Baptism, marriage and death records are often kept in free church archives. If you know where your ancestors lived, you can contact local churches to request information. Availability and access will vary greatly by region and individual church.

Canadian Citizenship by Descent Application Process

How to Apply for Proof of Canadian Citizenship

Most C-3 citizenship applications are done via physical mail. Once you gather all of your documents, follow these five steps to apply:

1. Print the [application packet and checklist](#).
2. Complete all forms.
3. Pay the [application fee online](#) and print the payment receipt.
4. Gather and attach all documents in the order shown on the checklist with the checklist on top.
5. Ship your application via regular mail or a courier service (recommended).
 - **Courier Address:** IRCC Digitization Centre - Proofs, 3050 Wilson Ave, New Waterford, NS, B1H 5V8
 - **Regular Address:** Case Processing Centre - Sydney - Proofs, P.O. Box 10000, Sydney, NS B1P 7C1

If you are applying from outside Canada or the United States, mail your application to your country's [Canadian embassy, high commission, or consulate](#) instead. Check with your closest Canadian consulate for exact instructions.

What Happens After I Apply?

You'll receive a mailed or emailed Acknowledgement of Receipt (AOR) from the IRCC in about 30–45 days (for applications from Canada or the U.S.). This confirms they have checked your application for completeness and started processing.

If something is missing, the IRCC will mail the application back to you explaining the deficiency. You can resubmit it with the corrected information. There will be another 30–45 day processing period to get your final AOR if everything is correct.



After that, you simply wait for processing. This typically takes at least 10 months. If approved, you'll receive your Citizenship Certificate in the mail!

How Much Does It Cost to Apply for CA Citizenship by Descent?

There is a \$75 proof of citizenship (citizenship certificate) fee due when you apply. You'll probably also pay around \$25 to \$50 USD each for copies of certified documents. In my case, I paid around \$300 USD to request all of my documents from multiple authorities.

How Long Does It Take?

As of April 2026, the IRCC estimates a 10-month processing time for new applications. Over 56,000 people are already in the application processing queue. With increasing demand, you may want to prepare for a longer wait time. You can [check the latest official estimate on the IRCC site](#).

Note: Between the time needed to gather your documents and application processing, this is not a fast way to leave the United States. If you are in acute danger, explore alternative options while you apply for citizenship.

Can I Request Urgent Application Processing?

There is an [urgent processing option for qualifying cases](#). One example is being at high risk due to sexual orientation, gender identity or gender expression. But, even if you have one or more of the qualifying factors, there is no guarantee you will be granted urgent processing.

To [request urgent processing](#), **submit an explanation letter and supporting documents** with your application, such as:

- A plane ticket or itinerary, with proof of payment
- A letter from your employer or school
- A doctor's note
- A death certificate
- Court orders for gender/name change
- Police reports from hate crimes or harassment

If you didn't submit an urgent processing request but wish to now, **do not resubmit a new application**. This will start a secondary audit of your documents and cause major delays.



Instead, you can add an [urgent processing request online](#) once you receive your AOR for the initial application.

Do I Need to Get a Canadian Passport?

No, but you may want to consider getting a Canadian passport as part of your move timeline since the process is often easier from outside of Canada.

- To qualify for a Canadian passport **from within Canada**, you need [two references and a guarantor](#). The guarantor must work within one of the specific qualifying fields, have known you for two years, and be a permanent citizen or resident.
- If you apply **from outside of Canada**, you still need references but can work with a [professional guarantor](#) instead. No personal connection is required.

Processing takes about four weeks plus mailing time. The passport fee is \$194.25 for 5 years or \$266.25 for 10 years. You'll need your citizenship certificate in hand **before** you can apply for a passport.

Do I Need Legal Support?

The Canadian citizenship by descent application is doable without legal aid. Many people have successfully applied without an immigration attorney. Oftentimes a professional genealogist might actually be more helpful for this process.

That said, people with complicated cases may want to seek legal help to review their application documents. You can always do an initial consultation, which often costs roughly \$200–\$500 USD. If you decide to work with an immigration attorney, be sure they have experience with Citizenship by Descent cases.

More C-3 Bill FAQs

We asked the Help Me Leave community for their specific questions about citizenship by ancestry. Here are answers to some of the most common questions about Bill C-3 and Canadian immigration.

Can I enter Canada on a visiting basis, then apply for citizenship?

Technically, yes you can. Check the Canadian law in regard to your native country. For example, with a U.S. passport, you can stay in Canada for [up to six months without a visa](#).



However, applying for proof of citizenship under Bill C-3 typically takes longer than that and won't give you the right to stay in the country while it's processed.

If you stay in Canada after the six months have expired, you will be in the country illegally unless you [get a visitor record extension](#).

Can I sponsor my spouse or family once I get proof of citizenship?

Yes, once you receive your certificate of citizenship, you can legally sponsor your spouse and/or children. This process typically takes around a year and may require legal counsel.

Your spouse may not be able to live in Canada with you during the application time. The normal visa limits apply to your spouse while they're applying with your C-3 sponsorship.

How can I determine if my ancestors who immigrated to Canada were naturalized?

Most Canadian naturalization records from 1854 to the present are held at [Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada](#). A portion of the records are available on the digital archives. For access to all records, you can request an official [Search of Citizenship Records](#). This costs \$75 and takes about 17 months to process.

However, naturalization records alone are not sufficient to prove citizenship. Because Canadian citizenship did not exist as a legal status until the 1940s, many peoples' Canadian ancestors never went through the naturalization process. So, these records may not be useful evidence in most cases.

Are U.S. census records or draft registration certificates acceptable proof that the ancestor was Canadian?

Military draft registration certificates or U.S. census records listing Canada as your ancestor's birthplace count as secondary documentation. They can help build your chain of evidence, although you may want to submit multiple second-tier records to continue to build your case.

Always try to get primary evidence of birth. But if you can't, show that you tried to get it. For example, an email from a church saying that a baptismal record doesn't exist would at least prove that you attempted to find it.



Will I be able to get a job in Canada?

Canadian jobs can be difficult to find, although it is easier without needing visa sponsorship. If you work in an [in-demand field](#) like healthcare or technology, finding employment will likely be easier.

It's important to note that Canada has a notoriously high cost of living, especially in major cities. While getting proof of citizenship is a huge step, you'll also need to be properly equipped to set up a new life in Canada. Don't overlook housing and employment access.

More Resources

- [Application Sample Templates](#)
- [Guide for Paper Applications for a Citizenship Certificate](#)
- [How to Track Your Application Status](#)
- [r/CanadianCitizenship wiki](#)
- [FamilySearch: Canada Vital Records of Birth, Marriage, and Death](#)